
CACR Depot Access Road — Impact on Cycleway, N25 Alternative Route, and Public Benefit

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To: padraig.barrett@corkcoco.ie

Cc: john.slattery@corkcoco.ie

Bcc: Adrian o'sullivan <adrian.browndog@gmail.com>

Dear Mr Barrett,

I am writing to you as a directly affected resident near Ballyrichard, Carrigtwohill, Co. Cork, regarding Irish Rail's selection of Option 7 as the preferred depot access road for the Cork Area Commuter Rail (CACR) maintenance facility. This proposal was developed by Roughan & O'Donovan Consulting Engineers on behalf of Irish Rail and has been met with overwhelming public opposition from East Cork. I am raising this directly with Cork County Council because the selection has implications for infrastructure and planning work that falls within the Council's remit.

Option 7 conflicts with the Carrigtwohill to Midleton Cycleway

Cork County Council has invested considerable effort in the Carrigtwohill to Midleton Inter-Urban Cycleway Phase 2, for which a Part 8 Planning Application was submitted in December 2023. The proposed Option 7 corridor runs through the same agricultural landscape that this cycleway is designed to traverse. The introduction of a depot access road carrying HGVs, low-loaders, and round-the-clock operational traffic through this corridor would fundamentally undermine the character and safety of the cycleway as planned. The Council should not allow a consultants' recommendation on behalf of Irish Rail to compromise a strategic active travel investment that the Council itself has brought through the Part 8 process.

Option 4 — an opportunity for the Council to deliver dual benefit

Option 4 presents a genuine opportunity. By incorporating the upgrade of Ballyadam Bridge and Gortagousta ("Hedgy Boreen") as part of the Option 4 works, the Council and Irish Rail could together deliver infrastructure that serves the public as well as the depot. The Carrigtwohill to Midleton corridor has no viable alternative route in the event of an eastbound incident on the N25 — a road whose upgrade scheme has not been allocated funding (Cork RDTF, corkrdo.ie) and for which no delivery timeline exists. With the Water-Rock residential development now proceeding and set to bring significant additional traffic to the area, the absence of an alternative route becomes an increasingly serious gap. An upgraded Ballyadam Bridge, and 'delivered as part of Option 4, would address this directly — providing residents, commuters, and emergency services with an alternative when the N25 is blocked or congested. Option 7 delivers none of this. It is, in effect, a private access road built at public expense, serving only Irish Rail staff while the surrounding community continues to bear the consequences of an overburdened N25 with no alternative.

Residential and ecological harm

Irish Rail's own assessment acknowledges that Option 7 introduces HGVs and low-loaders to a residential area — recorded as a positive impact in the deeply flawed Option Selection

Report. The route scores Highly Negative on Noise and Vibration — the worst possible rating — with nine residential receptors within 100 metres and some within 30 metres. Our house is 10m from our front boundry and the road will take some of our front garden. They score this as a Highly Positive Impact on property value. It is the only option that permanently acquires residential garden curtilage. Independent ecological survey work confirms five Annex IV bat species and two BoCCI Red-listed bird species using the corridor, and the route has confirmed hydrological connectivity to the Great Island Channel SAC. Photographic evidence held by residents shows the land along the proposed route already flooding under existing conditions — contradicting Irish Rail's own Neutral flood risk rating for this option.

The ask

I ask Cork County Council to formally raise objection to the selection of Option 7 with Irish Rail and to engage with the Department of Transport regarding the opportunity that Option 4 — particularly when combined with a Ballyadam Bridge upgrade — presents for delivering genuine public infrastructure benefit. The public consultation closes on 19 June 2026.

Full technical grounds, source document references, and photographic evidence are available at <https://no2option7.org/technical-evidence.html>

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss this further.

Yours sincerely,
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